

Nicolas Jao - Dry & Flaky Scalp

Background

- Have always had a dry and itchy scalp growing up. Before, it was managed by using anti-dandruff shampoos that, when applied long enough, completely got rid of the itchiness and flakes
- Completed isotretinoin (Accutane) treatment around March 30, 2026; now October 2026 (about 6 months post-treatment) and it has become much worse after this and now the same shampoos I used don't work
- Don't know if it could be related (atopy or atopic triad), but I've also had:
 - Chronic coughs/throat clearing since I was a kid (still going on)
 - A mild allergy to house dust that I've apparently outgrown
 - Lungs fatigue faster than peers during sports
 - Previous bursts of eczema that was treated with betamethasone, now gone
 - Dots on skin on arms an aunt told is "skin asthma" but it's harmless (keratosis pilaris maybe?)

Main concerns

- DRYNESS: scalp is much drier than before Accutane
- FLAKES: lots of flakes everywhere
- FRIZZINESS: hair texture has changed post-Accutane, much drier than before treatment, gets frizzy and messy easily
- ITCHINESS: mild to moderate itch is present but not severe at baseline

Pattern of symptoms

- Itchiness is mostly fine when indoors and in cool weather, but I still have flakes
- Itchiness and flakes flare consistently whenever I:
 - Go outside in hot weather and bright sun
 - Do any physical activity that increases my internal temperature or makes me sweat
 - Eat spicy foods
- During flares:
 - Strong itchy tingling sensations across the whole scalp (but temporary)
 - More flakes
 - Heavy frizz with my hair changing shape

What I've tried

Hydrating Conditioners (no anti-dandruff properties)	
	
Tried for 1 week every other day. Feels like no improvement.	

Pyrithione Zinc



Tried exactly 2 times. Feels like it gets worse.



Tried for 1 month every 2 or 3 days. Short-term relief but long-term feels like no improvement.

Selenium Sulfide



My original shampoo that kept the flakes and itchiness at bay. Short-term relief, but feels like it doesn't work anymore. Still tried it a few more times and feels like no improvement.

Ketoconazole



Currently trying since last week. Dr. Leventis told me to try this until this appointment. So far there is short-term relief and reduction of symptoms, but after a while the flakes come back. Even walking outside in the sun when I'd usually get a flare, I did not get one. But I ate a spicy food and it did not stop that flare. Might need more time to see if it works.

Not yet known / to check

- Whether this is dry scalp, seborrheic dermatitis/dandruff (yeast), sun or UV sensitivity, allergy, or a mix
- Whether the trigger is UV, heat/sweat, or the outdoor environment (pollen, humidity, wind)
- Whether the dark yellow, dry, brittle flakes are dried serum/scratch crusts, true scale, or product/oil residue (not yet checked whether they come mainly from scratched spots)

Pictures

I don't have a picture of my flakes but they often look flat and dry (not greasy) like this:



Things I don't have

- No redness of the scalp
- No greasy or waxy flakes (flakes are dry and brittle, sometimes flat, sometimes like powder)
- No flakes around the eyebrows, sides of the nose, or behind the ears
- No itchy eyes, sneezing, or runny nose outdoors

Questions for the doctor

- Could this be lingering post-isotretinoin dryness or photosensitivity?
- Could seborrheic dermatitis or a yeast component be involved?
- Could an environmental allergy be contributing?
- What shampoo, treatment, or sun protection do you recommend for my scalp?
- How long might it take for my scalp and hair to return to normal?
- Could this be a mix of skin barrier damage and seborrheic dermatitis? What would the solution be?